

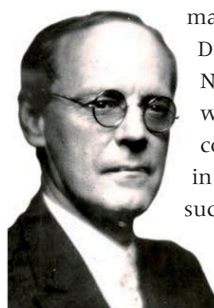


The North American T-6, also known as the Harvard, was used as a training plane during World War II

Great Manufacturers North American

Although perhaps not quite as well known as Boeing or Douglas, North American Aviation produced four of the world's most famous aircraft, and also one of the most remarkable—a giant, six-engine, triple-sonic strategic bomber, the XB-70 Valkyrie.

UNLIKE MANY great American aircraft manufacturers, North American Aviation (NAA) did not start out producing airplanes. Its original purpose was as a holding company that bought and sold shares in airlines, manufacturers, and other aviation-related activities. It was incorporated in Delaware by financier Clement Keys, who also founded Curtiss-Wright and TWA, and is sometimes referred to as “the father of commercial aviation in America.” However, such companies were broken up by the Air Mail Act of 1934, and under the leadership of James “Dutch” Kindelberger and chief engineer Lee Atwood (who had both been recruited from Douglas), North American Aviation moved from Baltimore, Maryland to southern California and began manufacturing aircraft. There were several benefits to this move—the better weather in California



Clement Melville Keys
(1876–1952)

was less likely to disrupt flight-testing and the greater Los Angeles area was already home to other aircraft manufacturers, including Douglas, Lockheed, and Northrop, so a highly trained workforce was available. The company initially specialized in trainers, and scored a huge success with the T-6, also known as the Harvard or Texan. At a time when most air forces were still operating biplanes, the T-6 was very advanced. A

powerful monoplane with an enclosed cockpit, retractable undercarriage, and variable-pitch propeller, it proved to be the perfect trainer for pilots progressing on to the fighters of World War II. More than 17,000 were produced, making it the bestselling military trainer of all time.

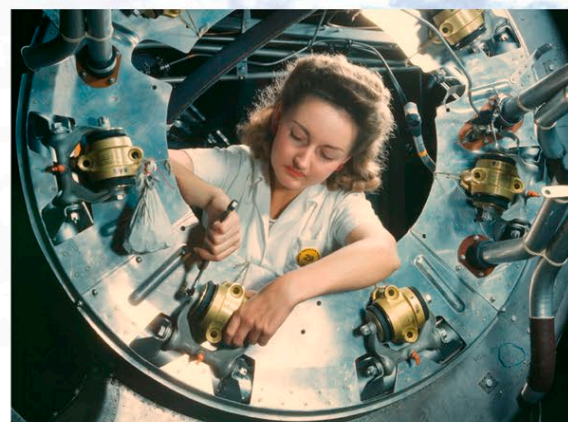
In 1940 NAA produced the P-51 Mustang to a British specification, going from the order being placed to first flight in an incredible 149 days. Once the airframe was fitted with the Rolls-Royce Merlin engine, the aircraft played a pivotal role in World War II because it had the range to escort the USAAF's bombers all the way to Berlin. Luftwaffe chief Herman Goering is alleged to have said “When I saw Mustangs over Berlin I knew the jig was up.” NAA also built the B-25 medium bomber, which achieved immortal fame during the famous “Doolittle Raid” of April 18, 1942, when 16 of them took off from the aircraft carrier USS *Hornet* and bombed Tokyo. During the war the company expanded at a tremendous

rate but, as with all the US armament industries, it contracted sharply after the Allied victory, with the company's order book shrinking from more than 8,000 aircraft to just 24 in a matter of months. The workforce contracted from 91,000 in 1945 to 5,000 the following year.

By this time the company was developing a new jet fighter, the XP-86. When early analysis of wind-tunnel data indicated that it would not be faster than the Lockheed Shooting Star already in service, NAA used data collected from Germany and changed the wing shape to a swept wing design. This delay to production was justified. The F-86 Sabre was the first fighter capable of supersonic flight (albeit in a dive) and became the most numerous western jet fighter ever made—around 9,800 were built in the US, Australia, Canada, Italy, and

P-51 Mustang

The legendary P-51 Mustang was used as a bomber escort during US air raids over Germany, and as a fighter by the British RAF.



Women workers

Nearly 10,000 B-25 Mitchell bombers were made before the end of World War II to be used by Allied forces. Many were constructed by female workers.



Share certificate

North American became a public company in 1948 as orders dropped following the end of World War II. This share certificate for the company dates from 1965.